

# Chicago Tribune



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MONDAY, MAY 5, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

## Appeals shift tax burden to homeowners

Report says system of assessment revisions has raised property tax bills for Cook Co. residents

By A.D. Quig  
Chicago Tribune

Cook County's property tax appeal process shifted \$1.91 billion in taxes from businesses onto homeowners over the last three years, exacerbating inequities in the city and suburbs, a new report found.

Homeowners' bills grew by a total of about 7% over that span as a result of the shift, according to the latest report from the Cook County treasurer's office, the first to calculate how much shifting burdens have cost on property tax bills. Those increases fell more on lower-income Black and Latino taxpayers, the report found.

The report does not draw conclusions about whether those appeals were correct, but does show "that the county's assessment appeal system works far more to the advantage of business property owners than homeowners, and at the same time favors wealthier white homeowners over lower-income minority homeowners."

It looked at the impact of appeals at the county assessor's office and the three-member Board of

Review during the 2021 and 2023 tax years. Though those years corresponded with much of the pandemic, its conclusions echoed similar findings from a Chicago Tribune and ProPublica investigation in 2017 about appeals' impact on assessments.

Properties are reassessed every three years. Every year, owners have two chances to knock down their assessments via appeals before the value is finalized: once at the assessor, next at the Board of

Review. If they're dissatisfied with those results, they can take their case to the Illinois Property Tax Appeal Board or to circuit court.

Owners of businesses have historically been far more likely to appeal. In the span of the study, nearly 64% of commercial building owners appealed, representing more than \$100 billion in value. More than 46% of all businesses were "serial" filers, appealing

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**"Food waste is not waste — it's a resource"** — Jason Feldman, CEO of the sustainability nonprofit Green Era



A truck dumps food waste into the anaerobic digester at the Green Era Campus in Chicago on April 25. The self-sustainable digester converts food waste to clean energy and nutrient-rich compost. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

## Composting campus aims to shake up waste management

South Side facility creates energy from food discards as it reduces methane emissions

By Adriana Pérez  
Chicago Tribune

At a once-vacant brownfield on the South Side of Chicago, a semitruck backed into an unassuming warehouse and unloaded a colorful batch of food scraps and spoiled products. The discards soon ended up in a massive tank that mimics a cow's digestion — minus the release of gassy byproducts — where they were turned into compost and renewable energy.

The anaerobic digester represents the culmination of a

combined effort by the Auburn Gresham community, politicians and scientists to change Chicago's approach to keeping food waste out of landfills, which are the third-largest source of human-related methane emissions in the country.

The operation is "the first facility in the U.S. dedicated exclusively to processing inedible food waste in packaging," according to a news release from Green Era Campus, which is run by a partnership of community groups and is home to the digester. By accepting still-packaged food, such as

chopped salad kits, pizzas in take-out boxes and produce in mesh bags that are separated before composting begins, the operation can reduce disposal costs for businesses and municipalities.

While anaerobic digestion is not a new technology and has long been used in agricultural settings, the campus is pioneering a closed-loop, zero-waste system that returns municipal food waste to the soil in the form of nutrient-rich compost and to the power grid in the form of renewable energy.

"In other words, food waste

is not waste — it's a resource," said Jason Feldman, CEO of the sustainability nonprofit Green Era, during a recent public unveiling. "The Green Era anaerobic digester is more than infrastructure, it's a community-powered climate solution."

Since operations began in April 2023, the digester has recycled over 40,000 tons of food waste from residents and businesses, according to Green Era leaders.

Two Mariano's grocery stores in Evergreen Park and Oak Lawn

**Turn to Waste, Page 2**

## Trump vague on due process

In TV interview, he's noncommittal: 'I'm not a lawyer'

By Aamer Madhani  
Associated Press

WEST PALM BEACH, Fla. — President Donald Trump is circumspect about his duties to uphold due-process rights laid out in the Constitution, saying in a new interview that he does not know whether U.S. citizens and noncitizens alike deserve that guarantee.

He also said he does not think military force will be needed to make Canada the "51st state" and played down the possibility that he would look to run for a third term in the White House.

The comments in a wide-ranging, and at moments combative, interview with NBC's "Meet the Press" came as the Republican president's efforts to quickly enact his agenda face sharper headwinds with Americans as his second administration crossed the 100-day mark last week, according to a recent poll by Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research.

Trump, however, made clear that he is not backing away from a to-do list that he insists voters supported in November.

Here are some of the highlights from the interview with NBC's Kristen Welker that was taped Friday at his Mar-a-Lago property in Florida and aired Sunday.

**Trump doesn't commit to due process**

Critics on the left have tried to make the case that Trump is chipping away at due process in the United States. Most notably, they cite the case of Kilmar Abrego Garcia, a Salvadoran man who was living in Maryland when he was mistakenly deported to El Salvador

**Turn to Trump, Page 5**

### INSIDE

#### Houthi's missile halts Israeli flights before war vote

A missile launched by Iranian-backed rebels in Yemen halted flights and commuter traffic at Israel's main international airport. It came hours before Cabinet ministers were set to vote on intensifying operations in Gaza. **Nation & World**

#### Gaza families face starvation due to Israel's blockade

Mothers agonize over their children, with nothing to eat as Israel's blockade of Gaza enters its third month, the longest since the war started. Hospitals, meanwhile, hang by a thread. **Nation & World**

## Group opposing Johnson and allies raises \$10M

Organization has about 90 donors, director says; progressives decry 'sucker politics'

By Jake Sheridan  
Chicago Tribune

The first well-funded shots against Mayor Brandon Johnson and progressive allies of his are being fired, two years before they face reelection.

A series of mailers sent earlier this year by the dark money Common Ground Collective argue "Chicago is in chaos" in a bid to beat up the mayor and four City Council members. The group behind the mailers is tight-lipped on where its cash comes from and what it plans to do next, but has a staggering amount of money to keep throwing punches.

The Common Ground Collective has raised \$10 million, according to its executive director, Chuck Swirsky. It's a sum that's sure to grow but that is already similar to the combined amount Johnson received in his 2023 campaign from his top funders, the Chicago Teachers Union, Service Employees International Union and related unions.

The group, a nonprofit, is not required to publicly disclose its donor list, and Swirsky declined to do so. But he said the money came from about 90 donors, none of whom have contributed

**Turn to Politics, Page 4**



Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson talks to Ald. Byron Sigcho Lopez, 25th, and Ald. Rossana Rodriguez Sanchez, 33rd, after a City Council meeting in May 2023 at City Hall. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 60 Low 48

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere  
177th year No. 125 © Chicago Tribune

